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From the age of sixteen, I was pretty much living on my own. With my mother throwing herself into her work, I often had her condo to myself. I set my own schedule, cooked my own meals, and did my own laundry. I was responsible for everything but paying the bills.

I had a 1992 white Honda Civic and drove it all over the state, listening to the indie alternative 99.1 WHFS—"Now Hear This" was one of its catchphrases—because that's what everybody else did. I wasn't very good at being normal, but I was trying.

My life became a circuit, tracing a route between my home, my college, and my friends, particularly a new group that I met in Japanese class. I'm not quite sure how long it took us to realize that we'd become a clique, but by the second semester we attended class as much to see each other as to learn the language. This, by the way, is the best way to "seem normal": surround yourself with people just as weird, if not weirder, than you are. Most of these friends were aspiring artists and graphic designers obsessed with then controversial anime, or Japanese animation. As our friendships deepened, so, too, did my familiarity with anime genres, until I could rattle off relatively informed opinions about a new library of shared experiences with titles like *Grave of the Fireflies*, *Revolutionary Girl Utena*, *Neon Genesis Evangelion*, *Cowboy Bebop*, *The Vision of Escaflowne*, *Rurouni Kenshin*, *Nausicaa of the Valley of the Wind*, *Trigun*, *The Slayers*, and my personal favorite, *Ghost in the Shell*.

One of these new friends—I'll call her Mae—was an older woman, much older, at a comfortably adult twenty-five. She was something of an idol to the rest of us, as a published artist and avid cosplayer. She was my Japanese conversation partner and, I was impressed to find out, also ran a successful Web-design business that I'll call Squirrelling Industries, after the pet sugar gliders she occasionally carried around in a purple felt Crown Royal bag.